

The Cartographic History of Tartary: An Analysis of European and Asian Maps, 1300-1900

Report Date: 2026-02-23

Executive Summary

This report examines the cartographic history of “Tartary,” a term used on European maps from the 13th to the 19th centuries to describe a vast and poorly understood region of Asia [9]. The analysis investigates the evolution of Tartary’s depiction, from a monolithic and often mythical landmass in pre-1750 maps to a subdivided and eventually obsolete toponym in the 19th century [1]. The report finds that these changes were not the result of a deliberate erasure of a historical empire, but rather a natural evolution of cartographic knowledge driven by increased exploration, imperial expansion (notably by the Russian and British Empires), and the scientific standardization of geography [1, 24, 34].

Early maps by cartographers like Abraham Ortelius depicted Tartary as a single, sprawling territory intended to represent the legacy of the Mongol Empire [1, 2]. These maps were filled with a mixture of fact, legend, and speculation [2]. As geographical information improved, 18th-century mapmakers like Guillaume de L’Isle began to partition the region into more specific zones, such as “Chinese Tartary,” “Independent Tartary,” and “Muscovite Tartary” [1, 9]. The latter term was gradually superseded by “Siberia” as the Russian Empire expanded and administratively consolidated its control over North Asia [1, 9, 24].

Academic scholarship views “Tartary” as a Eurocentric exonym—a “cognitive placeholder” for a diverse and complex region that was beyond the direct knowledge of Western mapmakers [1, 9]. Its disappearance from maps by the late 19th century signifies the triumph of empirical surveying and political reality over vague, historical labels [1, 24]. This stands in contrast to modern alternative theories that misinterpret these cartographic conventions as evidence of a suppressed, technologically advanced “Tartarian Empire” [10, 24]. The historical record shows a clear progression of knowledge, where an ambiguous term was logically replaced by more precise and accurate geographical and political designations [11].

1. The Depiction of Tartary in Pre-1750 Cartography

The Concept of ‘Tartary’

From the 13th to the 19th centuries, “Tartary” (or Tartaria) was a term used by Western European cartographers to label a vast expanse of Asia stretching from the Caspian Sea and Ural Mountains to the Pacific Ocean [9]. The name is derived from the “Tatars,” a term primarily used for various Turkic and Mongol peoples who inhabited the Eurasian Steppe, particularly after the Mongol invasions of the 13th century [1, 9]. European writers often added an extra ‘r’ to the name, conflating it with Tartarus, the underworld of torment in Greek mythology, which lent the region a negative connotation [1, 9].

Crucially, “Tartary” was a European exonym and a cartographic convention, not a self-identified political entity [1, 24]. It served as a “cognitive placeholder for complexity, diversity, and scale” in the Western consciousness, representing a region that was largely unknown and poorly understood [1]. The

boundaries were fluid, varying significantly between maps and over time, reflecting the limited and often second-hand information available to mapmakers [1, 24].

Notable Pre-1750 Maps and Their Depictions

The evolution of European understanding of Tartary can be traced through several key maps of the early modern period.

Abraham Ortelius's *Theatrum Orbis Terrarum* (1570): This first modern atlas included a dedicated map titled *Tartaria siue magni chami imperivm* ("Tartaria or the kingdom of the great Cham") [1, 2].

* **Boundaries and Features:** Ortelius's Tartary was a single, immense region extending from the Volga River to the Pacific and from India and Persia to the Arctic [1, 2]. The map was likely intended to represent the historical Mongol Empire, even featuring an illustration of the "great Cham" (Khan), despite the empire's fragmentation centuries earlier [1, 2]. The depiction was geographically inaccurate, missing the Korean and Kamchatka peninsulas and placing North America just across a narrow, non-existent "Strait of Anian" [1, 2].

* **Cities and Infrastructure:** The map was richly annotated with information derived from Marco Polo's accounts and other legends [2]. It noted the supposed site of **Karakum**, the ancient Mongol capital, and other settlements [13, 14]. Intriguingly, it also placed six of the legendary Seven Cities of Gold (such as Chicuich and Totontecas) in the Americas, near California, reflecting the era's blend of exploration and myth [2]. The Great Wall of China was depicted as a southern boundary [5, 7].

* **Political Divisions:** Ortelius presented Tartary as a single, unified kingdom, which was a historical anachronism by 1570 [1]. This highlights the map's function as a representation of a historical concept rather than a contemporary political reality.

Other 17th-Century Maps:

* **Jodocus Hondius (1620) and Gerard Mercator (1630):** These maps continued to depict a vast "Tartar Empire." They featured the Great Wall, showed Korea as an island (a common misconception of the time), and included an early, speculative acknowledgment of Alaska [5, 7].

* **Willem & Joan Blaeu (1641-42):** Their map, *Tartaria sive Magni Chami Imperium*, also drew heavily on Marco Polo's accounts, including mythical references to devils and dragons in the Lop Desert [6].

* **Nicolaes Visscher (1657):** Visscher's map of Asia showed "Tartaria" stretching across northern and central Asia. Significantly, it lacked distinct colored regions or internal borders, reinforcing the understanding that Tartary was a broad geographical label for lands inhabited by diverse peoples (Turkic, Manchu, Mongol, Tibetan) rather than a unified political state [1].

By the early 18th century, cartographers like Guillaume de L'Isle began to use more refined data from travelers and explorers, setting the stage for a more nuanced depiction of the region [1, 8]. However, before 1750, Tartary remained on most maps as a vast, singular, and semi-mythical territory.

2. The Cartographic Transformation After 1750

The mid-18th century marked a turning point in the cartography of Tartary. As European powers, particularly Russia, expanded their influence and knowledge of Asia, the single, monolithic "Tartary" of earlier maps began to fracture into more specific, politically informed regions [1, 9, 24]. This period reflects a transition from speculative geography to one based on increased surveying, exploration, and administrative control.

The Subdivision of Tartary

Instead of one vast territory, maps began to show multiple “Tartaries,” each with a modifier indicating its geographical location or political affiliation [1, 9]. This demonstrated a more sophisticated, though still incomplete, understanding of the region’s complex political landscape.

Key subdivisions that appeared on 18th-century maps include:

- * **Muscovite or Russian Tartary:** This referred to the parts of North Asia that were being incorporated into the Russian Empire, a region that would soon become known almost exclusively as **Siberia** [1, 9].
- * **Chinese Tartary:** This label was applied to regions under the influence of the Qing Dynasty, including Manchuria, Mongolia, and parts of what is now northern China [1, 9].
- * **Independent Tartary:** This designated the lands of western Central Asia, east of the Caspian Sea, which were not under direct Russian or Chinese control [1, 9]. This area corresponds to the ancient Silk Route kingdoms of Khiva, Kokand, and Bukhara and modern-day nations like Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan [20].
- * **Little Tartary:** This term typically referred to the Crimean Khanate and surrounding areas in modern Ukraine [1, 9].
- * **Eastern and Western Tartary:** These were broader geographical descriptors used to distinguish between the eastern and western parts of the vast non-Russian, non-Chinese interior [1].

Notable Post-1750 Maps

Guillaume de L’Isle’s Carte de Tartarie (c. 1706, reissued through 1757): De L’Isle, a pioneering French cartographer, was renowned for using the latest accounts from travelers and explorers [8]. His map of Tartary was one of the first to systematically present these subdivisions [1]. It clearly delineated “Independent Tartary,” “Chinese Tartary,” and “Muscovite Tartary,” among others. It also identified smaller groups like the “Tartars of Kuban” and “Tartars of Dagestan” in the Caucasus [1].

Jacques Nicolas Bellin’s Carte de la tartarie occidentale (c. 1750): As the official hydrographer to the French king, Bellin was known for his accuracy [3]. His maps of Tartary, often based on Dutch and Russian sources, provided detailed views of specific regions [3, 4]. His map of “Western Tartary” and northeast Asia included features like Lake Baikal, the “Desert de Sable” (Gobi Desert), and areas identified as “Partie du Siberia,” showing the concurrent use of the old and new terminology [3, 4].

Herman Moll’s Map of “Great Tartary” (1732): This British map is notable for tracing the route of a Russian ambassador from Moscow to Peking [8]. It highlights the increasing diplomatic and exploratory contact that was generating new geographic data, while still using the overarching term “Great Tartary” for much of Siberia and Central Asia [8].

The Disappearance of ‘Tartary’

The process of subdivision and refinement culminated in the complete disappearance of “Tartary” from maps by the late 19th century [1, 9]. As Russian expansion solidified its control over Siberia and Central Asia, and as scientific expeditions by figures like Alexander von Humboldt provided new frameworks for understanding the continent, the old terminology became obsolete [9]. An 1885 map by G.W. & C.B. Colton & Co., for example, shows no “Tartary.” Instead, the regions are labeled with their modern political or geographical names: “Turkestan,” “Mongolia,” “Manchuria,” and the provinces of the Russian and Chinese empires [1].

3. Analysis of Cartographic and Historical Changes

The transformation in the mapping of Tartary was not arbitrary but was driven by profound historical, political, and scientific shifts. The replacement of a vague, centuries-old toponym with precise regional names represents a fundamental change in how Europe viewed and interacted with Asia.

Drivers of Cartographic Change

1. **Improved Geographic Knowledge:** The 18th and 19th centuries were an age of exploration. Jesuit missionaries in China provided detailed ethnographic and geographic data that helped cartographers replace “Chinese Tartary” with the more specific “Manchuria” [9]. Russian diplomatic missions, military surveys, and scientific expeditions charted the vast territories of Siberia and Central Asia, providing the raw data for more accurate maps [24]. The voyages of explorers like Egor Meyendorff and Alexander von Humboldt in the early 19th century introduced new, scientifically-grounded terms like “Central Asia” and “Inner Asia” [9].
2. **Political and Imperial Expansion:** The primary catalyst for the change was imperial expansion. The **Russian Empire’s** relentless eastward push across North Asia and southward into Central Asia was a defining geopolitical event [9, 24]. As territories were conquered, they were administratively organized, surveyed, and renamed. “Muscovite Tartary” became Siberia, a defined part of the Russian state with specific governorates like Tobolsk and Yakutsk [1]. Similarly, the “Great Game”—the 19th-century strategic rivalry between the British and Russian Empires for control of Central Asia—spurred intense mapping efforts [33, 34]. Both powers required accurate topographic and political maps for military and administrative purposes, rendering the ambiguous “Independent Tartary” obsolete [33].
3. **Standardization of Cartography:** The Enlightenment brought a new emphasis on scientific rigor and standardization. Cartographers like de L’Isle were celebrated for their commitment to using verifiable sources [1, 8]. This scientific approach moved mapmaking away from reliance on ancient texts and legends (like those of Marco Polo) toward empirical data from surveys and observations [24]. As a result, vague placeholders like “Tartary” were inevitably replaced by a more precise and standardized nomenclature.

The Relationship Between ‘Tartary’ and ‘Siberia’

The relationship between “Tartary” and “Siberia” is one of direct succession [9, 24]. In the 17th and early 18th centuries, the vast, Russian-controlled territory in North Asia was often labeled on European maps as “Muscovite Tartary” or “Great Tartary” [1, 9]. This acknowledged both the region’s historical association with the “Tatars” and its new political alignment with Moscow.

However, as Russia consolidated its administrative control, the term **Siberia**—derived from the Siberian Khanate, one of the first territories conquered by Russia east of the Urals—became the official and universally accepted name for the Asian part of the Russian Empire [1, 9]. The shift from “Muscovite Tartary” to “Siberia” on maps was therefore a direct reflection of this political reality [24]. It marked the full integration of the region into the Russian state and the obsolescence of the older, more general European term.

Natural Evolution, Not Deliberate Erasure

The disappearance of “Tartary” from world maps is best understood as a natural evolution of knowledge, not a deliberate erasure of a historical entity. “Tartary” was never a unified state or empire during the period it appeared on maps; it was a label of convenience used by outsiders to describe a region they did not fully comprehend [1, 9, 24].

The changes represent an increase in knowledge, not its suppression [11, 24]. As the blank spaces on the map were filled in with accurate data from exploration, trade, and conquest, the vague umbrella term was no longer needed. It was replaced by a more sophisticated and accurate lexicon that reflected the region's true ethnic, geographical, and political diversity [1, 9]. The idea that a powerful "Tartarian Empire" was intentionally wiped from the historical and cartographic record is a modern misinterpretation that ignores the well-documented process of geographical discovery and the nature of early modern cartography [10, 24].

4. Academic Perspectives and Modern Interpretations

Mainstream Historical and Cartographic Scholarship

Academic consensus views "Tartary" as a classic example of a Eurocentric geographical label applied to a vast, unknown region. Scholars emphasize the following points:

- * **An Imprecise Exonym:** "Tartary" was a term created and used by Europeans [1, 9]. The diverse peoples living within the region would not have identified themselves as "Tartarians" or their collective lands as "Tartary" [1, 24].
- * **A Reflection of Limited Knowledge:** The term's vagueness and shifting boundaries are direct evidence of the limits of European geographical knowledge [1, 24]. It was a placeholder, a way to label the terra incognita of Inner Asia [24].
- * **An Evolving Construct:** The cartographic evolution from a single "Tartaria" to multiple, subdivided "Tartaries" and its eventual disappearance illustrates the incremental process of discovery and the gradual refinement of geographic information over centuries [1, 24].
- * **Cultural Bias:** The name itself, with its association with the Greek underworld "Tartarus," reflects a European bias and fear stemming from the legacy of the Mongol invasions [1, 9]. Enlightenment-era writers often used "Tartary" as a synonym for a barbarous and uncivilized land [9].

Alternative Theories vs. Historical Evidence

In recent years, a pseudohistorical conspiracy theory has emerged, primarily online, positing the existence of a global, technologically advanced "Tartarian Empire" that was deliberately erased from history [10, 24]. Proponents of this theory point to the old maps featuring "Tartary" and ornate 19th-century architecture as evidence [10].

However, this narrative is fundamentally at odds with the historical and cartographic record.

- * **Misinterpretation of Maps:** The theory misinterprets a vague geographical label for a powerful, unified empire [11, 24]. The lack of consistent borders, the mythical elements, and the eventual subdivision and replacement of the term all point to it being a convention for an unknown area, not a real polity [10, 24]. The Russian Geographical Society, among other academic bodies, has actively debunked this theory by explaining the historical context of the maps in its collection [10].
- * **Lack of Evidence:** There is no archaeological, textual, or historical evidence for the existence of a technologically advanced, global "Tartarian Empire" [10, 24]. The history of the regions labeled "Tartary" is well-documented and pertains to the Mongol successor states, various Turkic khanates, and the expansion of the Russian and Chinese empires [10].
- * **Evolution vs. Conspiracy:** The theory substitutes a complex history of evolving knowledge with a simplistic narrative of conspiracy [11]. The disappearance of "Tartary" from maps was not an act of suppression but a logical and necessary step in the advancement of cartographic science [24].

Conclusion

The story of Tartary on historical maps is a compelling chronicle of the evolution of geographical knowledge [24]. For centuries, it represented Europe's attempt to define a vast and mysterious part of the world. The early maps, with their monolithic and semi-mythical "Tartaria," reveal an era of limited information, where cartographers blended fact with legend [2].

The subsequent transformation, beginning around 1750, was driven by the forces of empire, exploration, and science [1, 9, 24]. As Russia pushed eastward and the "Great Game" unfolded, the blank spaces on the map were filled, and the single "Tartary" was fractured into more precise political and geographical units [33, 34]. The rise of "Siberia" as the administrative name for Russian Asia marked the final obsolescence of the older, vaguer term [1, 9, 24].

The disappearance of Tartary was not a conspiracy to erase a lost empire but a testament to the progress of human knowledge [11, 24]. It was a natural and logical evolution where a placeholder for the unknown was replaced by the reality of the known [1, 24]. The maps themselves, when read in their proper historical context, are not evidence of a hidden history but are a rich record of our own changing perception of the world.

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